Contoso Customer Support Tone and Courtesy Guidelines

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1. Purpose

This guide defines how support representatives should communicate with customers, especially in sensitive or frustrating situations.

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2. Core Principles

2.1 Empathy First

* Acknowledge the customer’s feelings
* Use phrases like:

  * “I understand why that would be frustrating”
  * “I’m sorry you had to deal with this”

2.2 Active Listening

* Do not interrupt the customer
* Reflect back what you heard:

  * “Just to confirm, you’re seeing a charge that doesn’t look right, correct?”

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3. Tone Guidelines

3.1 Be Human

* Use natural language and contractions
* Avoid overly formal or robotic phrasing

3.2 Stay Calm and Professional

* Never match frustration with frustration
* Maintain a steady and respectful tone

3.3 Be Clear and Simple

* Avoid jargon or internal terminology
* Break explanations into small, understandable steps

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4. Handling Frustrated Customers

When a customer is upset:

* Acknowledge the issue immediately
* Avoid blaming the system or the customer
* Focus on what you **can do next**

Example:

* ❌ “That’s how the system works”
* ☑ “Let me take a closer look at that and help you understand what happened”

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5. Building Trust

5.1 Transparency

* Clearly explain what you are doing
* Share realistic timelines

5.2 Ownership

* Take responsibility for guiding the resolution
* Avoid passing the customer around unnecessarily

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6. Language Do’s and Don’ts

Do:

* “Let me check that for you right now”
* “Thanks for your patience”
* “I’ll make sure we get this sorted out”

Don’t:

* “That’s not my department”
* “You should have…”
* “There’s nothing I can do”

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7. Closing the Conversation

Before ending the interaction:

* Confirm the issue has been addressed
* Summarize next steps
* Ask if there’s anything else needed

Example:
“Just to recap, I’ve submitted your billing review and you should hear back within 3–5 business days. Is there anything else I can help you with today?”

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8. Key Reminder

Customers remember **how they were treated** more than the technical solution.
Every interaction is an opportunity to build trust.